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California could ban Skittles, Hot Tamales and other candies

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Skittles, Hot Tamales, Dubble Bubble Twist Gum and other candies could be banned in California as a new bill seeks to prohibit processed foods containing chemicals lawmakers say are “toxic and dangerous.” Introduced by Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel (Democrat), Assembly Bill 418 would ban the manufacture, sale, or distribution of any food product in the state containing Red Dye No. 3, Titanium Dioxide, Potassium Bromate, Brominated Vegetable Oil, or Propyl Paraben. While consumers may not recognize these chemicals, they are common food and beverage additives. Titanium Dioxide, for example, is typically found in candies, pastries, chewing gum, coffee creamers, chocolates and cake decorations, while Red Dye No. 3 is a synthetic dye made from petroleum that gives food and drinks a bright, cherry-red color. In a statement, Gabriel said many of these chemicals have never been independently evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) or were last reviewed decades ago. “Instead, these chemicals have entered the nation’s food supply through a loophole in federal law—known as GRAS, or ‘generally recognized as safe’—that was intended to apply to common household ingredients like vinegar,” according to Gabriel. “As a result of this loophole, chemical companies have added new substances to the food supply with almost no meaningful federal oversight.” Gabriel highlighted that scientific studies have demonstrated significant public health harms from these chemicals, including an increased risk of cancer, behavioral issues in children, harm to the reproductive system, and damage to the immune system. “Californians shouldn’t have to worry that the food they buy in their neighborhood grocery store might be full of dangerous additives or toxic chemicals,” Gabriel said. “This bill will correct for a concerning lack of federal oversight and help protect our kids, public health, and the safety of our food supply.” The legislation would make California the first American state to ban these chemicals in processed foods, following in the footsteps of the European Union which has prohibited these additives. The bill is set to be heard in committee in the coming weeks, Gabriel said. It is expected to be heard in the Assembly’s Environmental Safety and Toxic Materials Committee first and, if passed, will go on to the Assembly’s Health Committee. Contact the author at emily.jarvie@proactiveinvestors.com Follow her on Twitter @emilyjjarvie

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